BuildLinka

Suggestions for real-world launch

What is needed to turn the current prototype into an app real vendors, workers, engineers and buyers can trust with real orders and real money. 30 September 2026.

Summary. The design and screens are strong and cover the right features. What is missing is the "engine" behind them: user accounts, a server and database, real payments with protection for both sides, verification of people, and delivery. The suggestions below are ordered by importance. Start small: one city, buyers and vendors first, then add workers, engineers and delivery.

1. Fix first (before any real testing)

Fix	Why
Create the "My jobs" screen or point "View all" to an existing screen.	Currently opens an empty "not found" page.
Make Hire and Apply buttons on Nearby work (open the hire form / apply form).	Testers will think the app is broken.
Save the chosen profile on the phone and add a "My dashboard" button on the Profile tab.	Users should not choose their role every time.
Link the Delivery dashboard, or hide it until the delivery role is ready.	Unfinished screens confuse reviewers.
Remove the fixed admin PIN. Admin must be a real admin account checked by the server.	A PIN inside the app can be found by anyone.
Upgrade to Expo SDK 57 before public release.	Fixes a known memory problem in the JS engine.

2. The foundation every profile needs

Accounts and login

- **Phone number + SMS code (OTP)** as the main login. Most users in Nigeria are phone-first; email can be optional.
- **One account, more than one role.** A vendor may also be a buyer; an engineer may hire workers. Let users add roles.
- Roles and permissions must be checked on the **server**, not only in the app.

Backend (server and database)

- Use a managed backend so the team does not run servers. **Recommended: Supabase** (PostgreSQL database, login, file storage, security rules). Orders, stock, projects and payments are related data, which a SQL database handles well. Firebase is a good alternative if the team already knows it.
- Store product photos, profile photos and documents in cloud storage, compressed on the phone first to save data.
- Real **push notifications** (expo-notifications) for new orders, hire requests, delivery updates and low stock.
- Keep the phone app working on slow networks: cache lists, show saved data offline, retry when the network returns.

Payments and trust

- **Paystack** (already in the design) for card, bank transfer and USSD. Payment must be confirmed by the server (Paystack webhook), never only by the app.
- **Escrow / held payment**: the buyer pays, BuildLinka holds the money, and releases it to the vendor after delivery is confirmed, or to the worker after each job milestone. This is the main reason people will trust the platform.
- Paystack split payments / subaccounts to pay vendors and workers automatically and keep BuildLinka's commission.
- Clear refund, cancellation and dispute process, with an admin screen to resolve disputes.
- Reviews only allowed after a completed order or job, so ratings are real.

3. Suggestions per profile

Vendor

Suggestion	Real-world reason
Business verification: CAC registration, owner ID, shop address and photos. Show a "Verified vendor" badge.	Buyers fear fake sellers.
Stock goes down automatically when an order is placed; vendor accepts or rejects each order.	Stops selling items that are out of stock.
Sell in real units: bags, tonnes, lengths, trips (e.g. sand/granite by truck). Bulk price tiers.	Builders buy in large, mixed units.
Fast price update screen (update many prices at once).	Cement and iron rod prices change often.
Set delivery areas and fees, or use BuildLinka delivery.	Heavy goods; delivery cost matters a lot.
Payout history, statements and downloadable sales report.	Vendors need records for their business.

Worker

Suggestion	Real-world reason
Identity check (NIN) and phone check; optional trade certificate. "Verified" badge.	Clients let workers into their property.
Portfolio of past work photos on the profile.	Clients judge quality by past jobs.
Hire requests the worker can accept, decline or counter-offer (price, date).	Real jobs are negotiated.
Milestone payments held in escrow, released when the client confirms work.	Protects both worker and client.
Availability calendar instead of only an on/off switch.	Avoids double booking.
Keep phone numbers hidden until a job is accepted (in-app chat or call).	Stops deals leaving the platform and protects privacy.

Engineer

Suggestion	Real-world reason
Verify the COREN licence number before showing the engineer badge.	Engineer approval is a legal and safety matter.
Shared project workspace linking the buyer (owner), engineer, workers and vendors.	One place for all people on a site.
Bill of Quantities (BOQ): engineer lists materials; the buyer can order it all in one tap.	Connects planning directly to sales.
Site inspection reports with photos, GPS location and time stamp, and a sign-off.	Proof of work and quality control.
Document upload with versions and approvals (drawings, specs).	Specs change during a project.
Budget and "spent" filled automatically from real orders and worker payments.	Accurate cost tracking, no manual typing.

Buyer

Suggestion	Real-world reason
Order tracking with live status and delivery confirmation code (OTP) or photo on delivery.	Proof the goods arrived.
Compare the same product across vendors by price, distance and rating.	Buyers shop around for the best price.
Project budget tracker: plan vs actual spending for each project.	Most builds go over budget.
Turn a Build Project plan into a ready cart and a list of workers to hire.	Makes the planner useful, not just informative.
Schedule delivery date and time to match site work.	Sites cannot store everything at once.
Pay in parts (per stage) for large projects.	Buyers build in stages as money comes in.

4. Delivery (logistics)

- Add a fifth profile, **Driver / Logistics partner**, using the delivery dashboard that already exists.
- Delivery fee based on distance and weight/volume (a truck of blocks is not a bike parcel).
- Driver app: accept delivery, navigation, pickup confirmation at the vendor, delivery confirmation with buyer's code and photo.
- At the start, partner with existing truck owners and logistics companies rather than owning vehicles.

5. Admin and operations

- Move the admin panel to a **separate web dashboard** with its own secure login (two-step verification), not inside the phone app.
- Approval queue for new vendors, workers, engineers and listings (the "submitted for review" message already expects this).
- Dispute and refund handling, user suspension, and report of fake listings.
- Customer support by WhatsApp and phone, with a help center inside the app.
- Crash and error reporting (e.g. Sentry) and usage analytics to see where users drop off.

6. AI Building Assistant

- Connect the chat to a real AI model through BuildLinka's server (never put the AI key inside the app).
- Base estimates on **real prices** from vendors on the platform, not fixed numbers, so the plan matches the market.
- Show a clear note that it is an estimate, and offer "Get an engineer to review this plan", which also brings work to engineers.

7. Local needs, law and safety

- Nigeria Data Protection Act (NDPA): privacy policy, consent, and secure storage of IDs and personal data.
- Terms of service covering payments, escrow, cancellations and disputes.
- Languages: English first, then Hausa, Yoruba, Igbo and Pidgin.
- Works on low-cost Android phones and slow networks: small images, fast loading, low data use.
- Payment options Nigerians use: bank transfer, USSD and card, and possibly pay-on-delivery for trusted buyers.

8. How BuildLinka can earn money

Source	How
Commission	A small percentage on each material order and each worker job paid through the app.
Delivery margin	Part of each delivery fee.
Vendor subscription	Monthly plan for more listings, analytics and store branding.
Featured listings	Vendors and workers pay to appear in featured banners and top of search (banner system already exists).
Pro tools	Paid project workspace features for engineers and construction companies.

9. Suggested roadmap

Phase	What to build	Goal
1. Fix and test	Fixes in section 1, internal test builds (EAS), test with 10 to 20 real users.	Stable prototype.
2. MVP launch in one city (e.g. Abuja)	Login, backend, vendor listings and stock, buyer orders, Paystack with escrow, push notifications, admin approval. Vendor and Buyer profiles only.	First real orders.
3. Workers	Worker verification, hire requests, milestone payments, reviews, availability calendar.	Hire through the app.
4. Engineers and delivery	COREN check, project workspace, BOQ to cart, site reports; driver profile and delivery tracking.	Full project on one platform.
5. Growth	Real AI planner, more cities, languages, subscriptions and analytics.	Scale.

Advice: launch the buyer-vendor order loop first and make it excellent. When buyers trust BuildLinka with material orders, adding workers, engineers and delivery becomes much easier.